in their austere hill retreats. These inscriptions also confirm the major impact of Jain learning on Tamil culture, strengthening the case for the Jains being the real initiators of the first Sangam, held in Madurai probably no earlier than towards the end of the second century BCE, but which gave rise to more such assemblies and so helped to create the legend of a Sangam golden age.

Their emphasis on education and social equality makes the Jain monks and nuns prime suspects in the introduction of the Brahmi script to Tamil country in the form of Ashokan Brahmi, out of which emerged Southern Brahmi and Tamil-Brahmi in the second century BCE, after which came the Vatteluttu, or ‘rounded script’, and then the Pallava script in the sixth century CE, resulting in the distinctive Tamil script we have today.